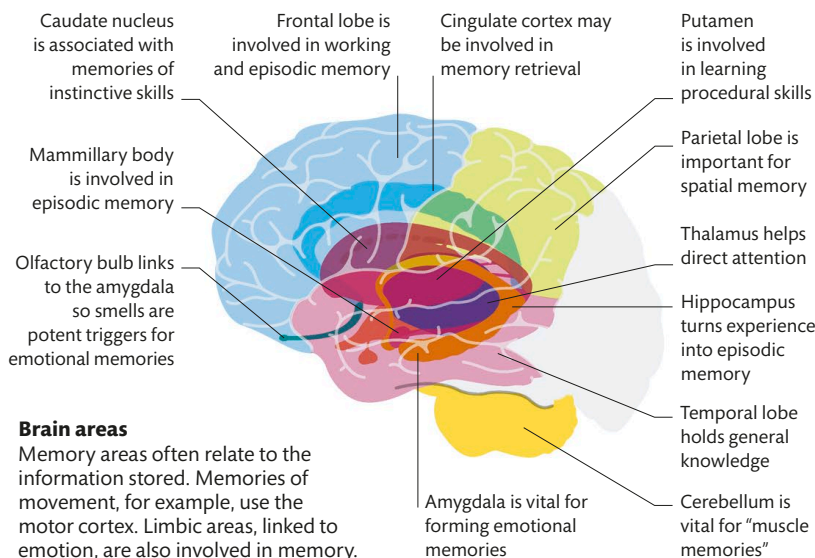


What Is Memory?

Our memory allows us to learn from experience and shapes us as individuals. Memory is not a single discrete brain function; there are several types, involving different brain areas and processes.

Memory in the brain

Memory includes instinctive processes that you are unaware of, as well as the more obvious parts that allow you to remember what you had for lunch yesterday or your boss's name. Each type of memory uses a range of different brain areas. Scientists used to think the hippocampus was vital for all new memories to form, but now it is thought this is the case only for episodic memories. Other types of memories use other areas, which are spread all around the brain.



Types of memories

To better understand how it works, scientists break memory down into a number of types. Many of these rely on different networks within the brain, although there is also a lot of overlap between the brain areas involved in each category.

